

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Higher Education and Research English

Conversation lab

Use these role cards to practice a response, handle a follow-up, and repeat with a new communication challenge.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For faculty, postdoctoral researchers, graduate students, lab managers, research administrators, grant staff, ethics-board coordinators, and academic program leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

How to use the conversation lab

1. Read the shared case. Spend two minutes noting the facts and your first response.
2. Assign roles. The responding professional uses role A; the listener uses role B. Read your own role privately before you begin.
3. Speak for 45-60 seconds. The listener asks a follow-up instead of simply agreeing. Continue until the meaning and next action are clear.
4. Reveal the model response. Identify one useful expression and compare it with your own wording.
5. Switch roles. Use the second-round challenge and speak again with fewer notes.

If you are studying alone

Speak both roles aloud. Leave a pause after the question, then answer without looking at the model. You can also write a four-turn exchange and read it back for clarity.

Useful conversation repair

- Could you say that another way?
- When you say that, which part do you mean?
- Let me check that I understood correctly.
- I need a moment to separate what is confirmed from what is still unknown.

Feedback

Judge whether the listener understands the situation and can identify the next action or unresolved question. Correct one meaning issue and one useful language pattern, then repeat.

CONVERSATION 01

Research Questions and Study Design

SHARED CASE

A research proposal asks whether a program "works" without specifying the outcome or population.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

What outcome would count as improvement, for whom, and over what period? A clearer research question will help us choose an appropriate design and describe its limits.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 02

Grant Proposals and Specific Aims

SHARED CASE

A grant draft promises to solve a broad scientific problem using a small pilot study.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The pilot can test feasibility and provide preliminary evidence. It cannot resolve the entire problem. I'll narrow the aim so the proposed work and the claim match.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 03

Lab Meetings and Data Challenges

SHARED CASE

A result differs from an earlier experiment, but the lab notes omit a protocol change.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ...

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could we compare the protocol versions and recorded conditions? Please add the missing change to the record so the team can assess possible explanations for the difference.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 04

Research Ethics and Human Subjects

SHARED CASE

A researcher wants to reuse participant data for a new question. The existing approval and consent materials have not been reviewed.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Does the proposed use fall within the relevant approval and consent arrangements?
Let's check with the appropriate ethics and data-governance processes before assuming reuse is permitted.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 05

Authorship, Collaboration, and Credit

SHARED CASE

Collaborators disagree about authorship late in a project. Their contributions and expectations have not been discussed together.

Role A | Responding professional

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Useful expressions

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could we document each contribution and review the applicable authorship criteria as a group? That will give us a clearer basis for the discussion than relying on assumptions about rank or effort.

Second round

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 06

Peer Review and Revision Responses

SHARED CASE

A reviewer points out that a manuscript's claim goes beyond its sample. The authors agree that the wording needs revision.

Role A | Responding professional

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Useful expressions

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Cover this until after your first attempt

Thank you for identifying this limitation. We have narrowed the claim to the studied sample and added a discussion of generalizability. The response should point the reviewer to the revised passage.

Second round

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 07

Data Management and Reproducibility

SHARED CASE

A shared dataset has variable names but no description of units, missing values, or collection dates.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ...

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you add a data dictionary covering units, missing-value codes, and collection dates? Those details will help another researcher interpret and reuse the data correctly.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 08

Academic Presentations and Conferences

SHARED CASE

An audience member asks whether a small study proves a general theory. The presenter needs a concise answer.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The study offers evidence relevant to the theory under these conditions. It does not establish the theory in every setting. A useful next step would test whether the finding holds in a broader sample.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

US Department of Education: FERPA

<https://studentprivacy.ed.gov/ferpa>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.